

NO ONE'S COMING!

"Pilot"

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FADE IN:

INT. HABITAT - EARLY MORNING

A modern home with circular walls. A hungover JEREMY BOSEMAN (Communications Engineer), late 20s, yawns and stretches as he swaggers down spiral stairs. A Texas thirst trap in sweats and a tank top, Jeremy's bemused eyes promise trouble and tenderness. He addresses an unseen virtual assistant with a gentle drawl.

JEREMY

Play some country, Horus. Somethin' from my Whiskey Whiplash playlist.

Jeremy steps off the stairs into a LOUNGE AREA showing signs of PARTYING from the night before. A homemade banner hanging crookedly on the wall reads: "Happy Birthday, Jeremy!"

HORUS (V.O.)

Are you sure you wouldn't prefer a feel-good tune, Jeremy? Uplifting music has analgesic effects to help relieve a hangover.

JEREMY

Now Horus, no need to get personal.

The wry Hank Williams classic *I'll Never Get Out Of This World Alive* fills the room. Jeremy heads toward the kitchen, but pauses at the sight of movement. We get our first real sign there's something off about this place when he crosses to a heavily-reinforced VAULT DOOR hanging ajar.

INT. ADJACENT ROOM - EARLY MORNING

Jeremy enters into a high-tech room, its walls a dense tangle of pipes, conduits, valves, tanks, lockers -- and an even more imposing SOLID METAL DOOR looming in the far wall.

A knee-high SERVICE ROBOT with a crude lipstick smile drawn on its face wheels around in circles, one articulated arm holding a tray of sloppy cocktails high, repeating: "Bottoms up! Bottoms up!" Jeremy laughs.

JEREMY

Don't mind if I do.

Jeremy downs a drink then stoops to power down the robot.

JEREMY (CONT'D)

How'd you get in here? Lukas is gonna have some choice words for you when he finds out --

Hearing a HEAVY CLANK, Jeremy turns his head to see the automated vault doors CLOSING. He dashes over -- too late. Nervous but forcing calm, Jeremy takes a deep breath.

JEREMY (CONT'D)
Horus, open the inner door.

HORUS (V.O.)
Opening outer door.

JEREMY
Dammit, Horus. I said inner door.

HORUS (V.O.)
Outer door will open in 30 seconds.

Jeremy glances over his shoulder at the ominous door behind him. His heart skips as he punches a code into a KEYPAD.

JEREMY
Stop countdown! Do not open the
outer door!

The keypad emits a rude ERROR BEEP. He tries again. Another BEEP. Hank's plaintive country lament keeps playing, as deep inside the walls we hear the HISSING SOUNDS of pneumatic air being forced into cylinders.

HORUS (V.O.)
Outer door will open in 20 seconds.

Panicking now, Jeremy POUNDS on the inner door glass --

JEREMY
I need help in here! Help! Somebody
open the fucking --

INSERT: From the Lounge Area, we see Jeremy's terrified face through the door's thick window. We can't hear his shouts.

HORUS (V.O.)
Outer door will open in 10 seconds.
9, 8, 7, 6...

Jeremy darts to a locker labeled EVA SUITS, knocking over the robot. He yanks open the door -- but it's EMPTY. No suits inside. Jeremy's entire body sags.

We PUSH INTO Jeremy's face as he realizes his young life is about to end, horribly. Glancing down, he spots a broken drink glass, grabs a shard, and rapidly CARVES into his palm.

HORUS (V.O.)
5, 4, 3, 2, 1...

The door of what we should realize by now is an AIRLOCK dramatically OPENS, revealing a windy red landscape beyond.

EXT. HABITAT - CONTINUOUS

Hank Williams keeps singing, as Jeremy staggers outside into a DUST STORM, freezing, gasping, but there's no oxygen. No air pressure. Jeremy stumbles toward A ROVER VEHICLE, hoping to make it to safety inside.

But once exposed to the lethally low atmospheric pressure, the moisture in his eyes flashes to vapor and the gasses in his blood turn to bubbles, making visible capillaries extend and burst. As Jeremy collapses to the red dirt, fizzy blood leaking from his burst veins --

WE RAPIDLY RISE to reveal a small outpost in a barren desert. As we ROCKET HIGHER into the blackness of space, we realize that desolate colony lies on the lonely red of PLANET MARS.

HANK WILLIAMS

*No matter how I struggle and strive,
I'll never get out of this world
alive.*

DIP TO BLACK.

EXT. MARS COLONY - SUNRISE

A series of ESTABLISHING IMAGES: A white sun tinged blue, low over a parched crater floor. A lonely landing pad in waiting. A pair of Rover vehicles, dinged and dusty. Finally, a CLOSE SHOT of Jeremy's SHRIVELED FACE lying against red rocky soil.

MA-RI (PRELAP)

*If you think dry winters are bad
for your skin, just imagine what
freakin' Mars can do to your
complexion.*

INT. HABITAT - MA-RI'S ROOM - INTERCUT

MA-RI CHO (Energy Systems Engineer), mid 20s, Korean, strikes a Bambi pose in athleisure wear as she records a video. Once shy and insecure, Ma-Ri's selection as a colonist brought media attention and acceptance that hit her like a drug. Now she's an off-planet, social media star, posting obsessively.

MA-RI (CONT'D)

*In today's Martian beauty hack,
I'll share a secret I use here at
the colony to keep my skin looking
dewy and lit from within all day --*

The door opens and ANYA KUMAR (Botanist), late 20s, Indian, bursts in. Tiny in stature but towering in spirit, Anya craves control and speaks with a formal Indian accent.

ANYA
Have you seen Jeremy?

MA-RI
Anya. Boundaries? You know Jeremy.
He's probably sleeping it off in
the lab.

Anya exits and we FOLLOW her into --

INT. HABITAT - CONTINUOUS

Anya crisply moves down hallways and around corners in search of Jeremy, providing us a brief tour of the intricately designed habitat that our colonists share. Anya reaches --

INT. SCIENCE LAB - CONTINUOUS

She enters an impressive scientific space with multiple work areas. Anya glances at the empty couch, then turns to LUKAS MÜLLER (Roboticist), 30s, German, aloof, working at a table. Dripping with irony, Lukas is the type who makes others feel he's doing them a favor just by talking to them.

ANYA
Lukas, have you seen Jeremy?

LUKAS
Not since he climbed on the mess
table last night to teach us the
Cowboy ChaCha. That was my cue to
tap out.

Anya exits and we HOLD on Lukas' calm face. TILT DOWN to reveal what he's doing -- cleaning the lipstick off the service robot that was in the airlock with Jeremy.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

CLAIRE TREMBLAY (Physician), 30, a lovely blend of kindness and confidence from Quebec, walks down the hall studying a MEDICAL TABLET DEVICE.

MATEO SOTO (Systems Engineer), 30, a charming Dominican from NYC, bursts shirtless from the shower area -- and they crash into each other, knocking the tablet from Claire's hands.

CLAIRE
Slow down --

MATEO
Watch it --

They turn to look at the tablet on the ground between them.

MATEO (CONT'D)

I got it --

CLAIRE

No you don't.

She stoops faster and retrieves her fallen tablet.

MATEO

Really? Is that where we're at now?
I can't show you a simple courtesy.

CLAIRE

Sure you can -- put your shirt on.

MATEO

Claire, nobody cares I don't wear a
shirt from the showers. Except you.

CLAIRE

It's disrespectful.

MATEO

It's practical.

CLAIRE

It's a cry for attention.

MATEO

That is so not true.

Anya rounds a corner and approaches.

ANYA

Looking dangerously fit, Mateo.

MATEO

(lights up)

Really?! You think so?

Claire rolls her eyes.

ANYA

Have either of you seen Jeremy?

Anya stops in front of a PICTURE WINDOW framing the Martian landscape, with Jeremy's distant FALLEN BODY in plain view outside, but nobody is looking out the window.

MATEO

Sorry, Anya.

CLAIRE

I'm afraid not.

ANYA

Claire, would you kindly check your medical monitor? I cannot find him anywhere.

CLAIRE

Sure, but if you had any cause for alarm I would've seen the alert.

As Claire consults her tablet, JULIA FRICKER (Psychologist), 30s, Rotterdam born and educated, brimming with opinions and fatalism, approaches wearing a bathrobe to hit the showers.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

That's weird. I'm not showing a signal for Jeremy.

When Julia draws nears, something out the window catches her attention. She pauses, spots Jeremy's body, and SCREAMS.

EXT. HABITAT - DAY

A sobering LOW-ANGLE SHOT of Jeremy's DESICCATED FACE and RAVAGED BODY in the foreground with the HABITAT behind, surrounded by low-lying support structures.

CLAIRE (PRELAP)

I can't believe he's really gone...

INT. COMMON ROOM - LOUNGE AREA - DAY

COMMANDER DANA GRAYSON, 50s, Australian, authoritative with a human touch, conducts a private briefing with Mateo, Claire, Lukas and Julia, all looking disconsolate.

CLAIRE

... How could this have happened?

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Based on the limited data available, the outer airlock door open at oh five twenty -- cause unknown. Jeremy was inside without a pressure suit. His loss will be felt deeply, by all of us... he was a good kid.

(beat; emotional)

But as my senior officers I need you four to keep the team on schedule today.

JULIA

What was Jeremy doing in the airlock at that ungodly hour?

MATEO

Probably the Cowboy ChaCha.
(off their looks)
Bruh was pretty hammered.

CLAIRE

What did the camera feed show?

COMMANDER GRAYSON

The camera failed to activate.

Lukas glances at an end table holding a dozen colorful 6-inch ACTION FIGURES, each one fashioned after a colonist. The figures stand on a plastic Mars terrain with the sign: "Heroes of Mars."

LUKAS

Or, Jeremy turned it off. You know,
so we didn't have to watch him open
the airlock and step into oblivion.

Lukas tips over the Jeremy figure on the stand.

LUKAS (CONT'D)

Sorry, someone had to say it.

CLAIRE

No. Nobody loved life like Jeremy.

JULIA

Welllll...

MATEO

Well what? Did he share something
in therapy we should know about?

JULIA

Without confidentiality, it's not
therapy -- it's betrayal. You all
keep secrets. Jeremy did, too.

That lands. They stare at each other. Abashed. Curious.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

As much as I look forward to reading
about this in your memoirs, our first
resupply ship arrives in 36 hours.
You need its food and oxygen to stay
alive, and I need it to take me home
to meet my new grandson. Now is the
time for focus. And a functioning
airlock.

LUKAS

I'll start FDR tests. See if there was a fault in the systems core.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Manual controls in the airlock until we isolate the problem.

(shifting gear)

In the meantime, the high-frequency antenna's out. So I can't brief Mission Control on our situation.

JULIA

Hell of a time to lose Earth.

MATEO

Probably the dust storm last night.
(springs to his feet)
I'll take a Rover team for repairs.

CLAIRE

We can't go outside the hab right now. Not with two system breakdowns in one day.

MATEO

The transport ship can't land without coms.

CLAIRE

Which we can repair *after* Lukas conducts a fault analysis. That's straight out of the manual.

MATEO

Can't follow the manual all the time, Claire.

CLAIRE

How about just once. Out of respect for our dead friend --

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Enough.

(calming breath)

You're settlers on a hostile planet. Loss of life was practically written into the travel brochure. Now is the time to remember your training and demonstrate control.

Mateo and Claire exchange a look.

COMMANDER GRAYSON (CONT'D)

Claire, retrieve Jeremy's body.
Winston can help. Mateo, take a
rover team to the Com Tower. We
need it operational before lunch.

(to Julia)

Julia. Anya lost her fiancé this
morning.

JULIA

I know. It's devastating.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

She needs the comfort and wisdom of
a trained psychiatrist. Make her
functional.

As the colonists split up to accomplish their tasks, we HOLD
on Julia, looking very nervous.

INT. KITCHEN - DAY

Ma-Ri fixes a cup of tea. Julia hurries up, panicked.

JULIA

Ma-Ri. I need help. Can you sneak
into Jeremy's room to retrieve my
"undergarments" from his bed? I'll
keep Anya busy.

MA-RI

You slept with Jeremy last night?

JULIA

Shh. Please, don't judge. It's not
productive. We're all devastated.

Ma-Ri glances into the Common Room, where Grayson now
consoles the teary Anya.

MA-RI

Not as devastated as his fiancé.

JULIA

Still judging. Still not helping.
After Jeremy's party, he hit on me,
and I kinda had a little too much.

MA-RI

You always have a little too much.

JULIA

Can you not hear the words you're
saying?

(MORE)

JULIA (CONT'D)

I'm already deep in the pit of a soul-crushing shame spiral. My focus is purely professional right now. I don't want to add trauma to Anya's grief. So go get my panties.

Ma-Ri considers as Anya approaches with big sad eyes.

ANYA

Julia...

JULIA

Oh, Anya. Come here, honey.

Julia opens her arms and enfolds Anya, who buries her head in her therapist's shoulder. Ma-Ri mouths silently to Julia: "You owe me." Off Julia, guilty and dying inside --

INT. AIRLOCK - DAY

Mateo stands at the locker labeled EVA SUITS and opens the door -- to our surprise it's now full of labeled pressure suits. Next to him stands HARLEY FAGIOLI (Mechanical Engineer), an Italian tomboy, all heart and passion and impulse. Right now she's brimming with grief and anger.

HARLEY

Fuck, fuck, fuck me. I don't want it to be true.

On the other side of her stands the powerfully built JABBAR SALIM (Structural Engineer), late 20s, Syrian born, full beard and soulful eyes. Jabbar lives in a perpetual state of gratitude after his childhood as an orphan in a refugee camp. They all start changing into EVA suits.

JABBAR

When my time comes, I'll be ready.

HARLEY

Jeremy was a sweet country boy. He made me laugh.

(tearing up)

He called me his Chattahoochee.

MATEO

You do know that means you're a hoochie who talks too much, right?

HARLEY

I know.

(she didn't)

How could this have happened?

Curious, Mateo pokes around for anything out of place and finds one of the fallen drink tumblers that the robot held. He retrieves the glass and sniffs it.

MATEO

Had to be an accident. Jeremy was drinking and made a mistake. Horus, what happened in the airlock this morning? Who opened the door?

HORUS (V.O.)

Jeremy initiated the outer door opening sequence.

JABBAR

Without his EVA suit on?

MATEO

Horus, did Jeremy initiate verbally or manually?

HORUS (V.O.)

(beat)

Unclear.

The three colonists trade troubled looks.

HARLEY

What the hell's that mean?

HORUS (V.O.)

Incomplete data. Perhaps if you rephrase the question I can --

Abruptly, Horus's voice GLITCHES OUT.

MATEO

Hey. What happened? Horus?

INT. SCIENCE LAB - INTERCUT

Lukas sits at his station, coolly monitoring a CCTV FEED of the three colonists suiting up inside the airlock.

LUKAS

Fault analysis software just kicked in. Computer systems are gonna be offline for a while. Sorry people.

Did Lukas switch off Horus to keep Horus from talking? Sure feels that way. Off Lukas' face, giving away nothing --

EXT. MARS SURFACE - DAY

The upbeat and glorious pop harmonies of *We Can Fly* by the Cowsills starts playing. In an AERIAL SHOT, we swoop down on ROVER ONE bouncing along the rough Martian landscape, gliding over berms in the reduced gravity. We can feel its speed.

Our colonists are pioneers, and this is their Wild West, and we want to capture the magic of that whenever we can. The Rover hits a large berm and LAUNCHES HIGH into the air. At the apex of its parabolic flight, we CUT INSIDE:

INT. ROVER ONE - INTERCUT

Mateo grips the wheel with Harley shotgun and Jabbar in back, weightless and adrenalized. They PLUNGE DOWN like a roller coaster and BOUNCE TWICE before the wheels find traction.

HARLEY

Make us fly, Mateo. I need to feel alive.

Ahead, the Rover approaches an even bigger berm and hits it hard. The vehicle FLIES EVEN HIGHER as the occupants inside WHOOP out loud.

Once the Rover lands, Harley notices a BLINKING LIGHT on the pressure suit's control pad built into the forearm.

HARLEY (CONT'D)

Hold on. Someone's trying to reach me on my private feed.

MATEO

Who's calling?
(annoyed)
Is it Claire?

Harley just smiles as she pulls on her helmet for privacy.

EXT. HABITAT - INTERCUT

Claire, wearing her pressure suit and helmet, trudges toward Jeremy's frozen body carrying a portable stretcher with help from WINSTON, who we'll meet in a moment.

CLAIRE

Harley, be safe out there, okay?
Mateo is reckless.

Mateo keeps glancing over, wondering who she's talking to, but he can't hear her with her helmet on.

HARLEY

And you're fierce. That's why I
love you both.

CLAIRE

I'm serious. I don't trust his
judgment.

HARLEY

Claire, you've got to find a way to
let go of the past. Eventually.
We're here for a lifetime.

Reaching Jeremy's ravaged body, Claire and Winston load his
stiff corpse onto the stretcher.

CLAIRE

I'll never let go. Not after what
he did to Adrienne. Just don't take
any chances until we figure out
what happened to Jeremy, okay? None
of it makes sense.

HARLEY

I'll be careful. Hey, did you know
what Chattahoochee means?

But Claire has ended the call. Harley removes her helmet.

MATEO

That was her, wasn't it? Is she
questioning my judgment again?
Listen, next time you talk to
Claire, you can tell her --

-- his words are cut off by a gut-wrenching METALLIC CRUNCH,
as the rocker arm SNAPS FREE. The Rover lurches to one side
and the world starts SPINNING AROUND US in a violent blur.

EXT. MARS SURFACE - DAY

As Rover One ROLLS DOWN a steep incline, bouncing violently --

SLAM TO BLACK.

DR. PETTIGREW (PRELAP)

Congratulations Mars Colony
candidates!

EXT. TRAINING COMPLEX - CENTER QUAD - DAY

CLOSE ON A BANNER: "Welcome Colonists! The Sky is No Longer
the Limit.

International Space Training Institute." CRANE DOWN on an outdoor campus in a lush park-like setting. In an open field, 200 hopeful Mars COLONISTS sit facing a stage.

DR. PETTIGREW
You are an elite group of
specialists, chosen from over
68,000 applicants around the world.

On stage, the formidable DR. MARY PETTIGREW, 40s, addresses the candidates with a formal English accent. A semicircle of INSTRUCTORS are seated behind her.

DR. PETTIGREW (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
But now the hard part begins. We
must determine which twelve of you
are best qualified to carry out the
mission of establishing the first
interplanetary settlement in human
history. So, for the next six
months, you will live together on
this campus.

We find Mateo sitting amongst the colonists. He scans the crowd, scoping out the competition, when he spots Claire a couple rows away.

Claire turns and meet his gaze. A spark flashes between them. Mateo cracks a smile. Claire returns it before turning back to the speaker.

DR. PETTIGREW (CONT'D)
Here you will undergo a series of
tasks and tests, mental and
physical, fair and unfair, all
designed to break you down and
crack you open, so we can study
what spills out. Those watches you
received in the mail with your
acceptance letters are biometric.

As candidates look at the smartwatches they all wear --

INT. OBSERVATION ROOM - INTERCUT - DAY

In a hidden viewing room at the training complex, a group of white-coated DOCTORS and PSYCHOLOGISTS and CORPORATE EXECS watch the candidates on multiple CCTV monitors.

DR. PETTIGREW
Your vital statistics are on
display to our evaluators, all the
time.

(MORE)

DR. PETTIGREW (CONT'D)

If you're unable to control
yourself on Earth, you'll never
survive life on a forbidding alien
planet, and we need to know now.

One MEDICAL TECH observes spiking levels on a monitor and punches up a CCTV feed -- to reveal a MALE CANDIDATE shaking and sweating. She speaks into a headset.

MEDICAL TECH

Candidate 37. Bradley Hoekendorf.
Multiple respiratory abnormalities.

On stage, Dr. Pettigrew pauses as she listens on her earbud.

DR. PETTIGREW

Case in point. Mr. Hoekendorf there
is having a panic attack. Please
escort Mr. Hoekendorf off campus.
His time here is done.

A shaken and sweating BRADLEY HOEKENDORF gasps, as MEDICAL PERSONNEL escort him away.

DR. PETTIGREW (CONT'D)

Make no mistake, if you receive an
early dismissal it's not cruelty,
it's a kindness. Both to you and
the colonists who will one day
depend on you for their lives.

EXT. TRAINING COMPLEX - CENTER QUAD - DAY

Later, after the speech, the colonists gather to meet one another and their instructors. Claire's in a small group listening to a painfully NERDY CANDIDATE drone on about dust particle mitigation. She turns and scans the crowd, when --

MATEO (O.C.)

Looking for someone?

Claire turns to see Mateo behind her.

CLAIRE

Maybe.

MATEO

And have you found them?

CLAIRE

I'm not sure. Too early to tell.

Mateo flashes that beaming smile.

MATEO

I can wait.

CLAIRE

You're patient. I like that.

MATEO

We're going to spend the rest of our lives together on Mars, so we've got nothing but time.

CLAIRE

Patient and cocky.

MATEO

It's a good combination, right?

CLAIRE

It got my attention.

MATEO

(steps closer)

So, you've found what you're looking for?

CLAIRE

I think I have...

Their eyes are locked -- we feel their heat and connection -- then Claire shifts her focus over Mateo's shoulder.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

She's right over there. Very nice to meet you.

Claire moves to a young female candidate we'll come to know as ADRIENNE, beautiful and noticeably younger than the other candidates. As the women hug, Mateo watches, intrigued.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. MARS SURFACE - RESUME

HIGH ANGLE on the Rover. HOLD for a long beat as dust blooms around it. What's going on inside? Can anyone survive that?

INT. ROVER ONE - DAY

All three riders are still strapped into their seats, dazed.

HARLEY

Well, that was unexpected.

MATEO
Anyone hurt?

ATTICUS (OVER RADIO)
Rover One. I'm showing you stopped
en route.

INT. HABITAT - SCIENCE LAB - INTERCUT

At a communications bay, ATTICUS WEST, an ebullient black Electrical Engineer from Ethiopia, monitors the Rover crew's GPS signature on a terrain map and speaks into his headset.

ATTICUS
Status?

MATEO
Uh, we're looking at a slight delay
here, base.

ATTICUS
What happened?

EXT. MARS - DAY

Moments later, the Rover One crew, wearing helmets now, has exited the vehicle and surveys the damage underneath.

MATEO
Rocker-bogie system on the left
front wheel failed.
(inspecting closely)
It's sheared clean through.

JABBAR
This Rover was literally designed
not to roll.

MATEO
And yet here we are.
(turns to Harley)
Can you make it go vroom vroom?

Relieved to have a task to distract her from her grief, Harley opens a Rover panel and starts pulling out tools.

HARLEY
Oh, I don't know. Could I design a
mechanical egg breaker and yolk
separator when my *nonna's* arthritic
fingers swelled like Tuscan blood
sausages?
(MORE)

HARLEY (CONT'D)

When *babbo* wanted to sweat out his Barolo after dinner, could I design an automatic self-folding dining room table to make room for the family to dance the tarantella?

JABBAR

What's she talking about?

Mateo smiles with bittersweet affection watching Harley.

MATEO

Nobody knows. You just gotta roll with it.

Harley starts working on the broken strut.

INT. LAB - DAY

Claire stands over a steel table holding Jeremy's desiccated body, cutting away his clothes. Burst capillaries and blood vessels spiderweb his clammy blue skin.

Across the table stands WINSTON BOSTWICK, tall, black, with a charming nonchalance. London born, Winston is the son of the British billionaire who funds the Mars colony. With a low self-image, Winston is ever trying and failing to live up to the legend of his father.

WINSTON

I don't think I can do this.

CLAIRE

I don't like it either.

WINSTON

No, really, I feel some sick coming up. You'd better find someone else to help.

CLAIRE

Everyone else is a scientific mission specialist, Winston. You, on the other hand, are a rich knob whose Daddy let shit in his nappies too long.

Winston looks up at Claire, wide-eyed.

WINSTON

Claire! What the fuck? That's brutal, babe.

CLAIRE

Look, you know I love you, but the stakes have risen and it's time to pull your weight. If it's a lab assistant I need, then that's what you'll be.

WINSTON

Fine. But I don't have to like it.

Claire resumes examining Jeremy's body. She uses a foot pedal to activate an audio recording device.

CLAIRE

The body is that of Jeremy Boseman, a normally developed Caucasian male, 28 years of age. Body is cold and unembalmed...

WINSTON

Moderate rigor setting in.
(off Claire's surprise)
I was Columbia pre-med. For a semester.

CLAIRE

What happened?

WINSTON

Human Anatomy Class. I couldn't sleep with women for a year after I saw what was under their skin. My father said I was just lazy.

CLAIRE

Your father believed in you enough to send you here.

WINSTON

To another planet. He just wanted to get rid of me, like the summer he shipped me off to a private seaside spa in the Maldives. Sheer torture.

CLAIRE

Okay, you can stop talking now.

Claire and Winston resume their examination, when Winston notices something.

WINSTON

His left hand's clenched in a fist.

Claire pries open the hand to find his palm a bloody pulp.

CLAIRE
Lacerations. Strange.

Using a sponge, she washes away the blood, revealing an odd
SWIRLING SYMBOL carved into the flesh of Jeremy's palm:



WINSTON
What's that?

CLAIRE
Looks like a Fermat's spiral. Based
on the blood flow, I'd say it was
carved before he went outside.

Winston leans forward in wonder.

WINSTON
A message from beyond the grave?
What's it mean?

CLAIRE
I don't know, but do me a favor and
don't tell anyone about it, yet.

WINSTON
Why not?

Claire stops working and stares meaningfully at Winston.

CLAIRE
After Commander Grayson hitches a
ride home on that supply ship, it's
just the eleven of us here. For the
rest of our lives. If we lost
Jeremy due to human error, fine.
But if someone's covering it up, we
need to know now. Don't you think?

WINSTON
Totes.
(then)
I was one of the last ones who saw
Jeremy alive. How do you know I'm
not hiding anything?

CLAIRE
You're not smart enough.

WINSTON
I'm not, am I?

CLAIRE
Let's finish up here. When we're done, we can store Jeremy's body in his room until the memorial.

Off the mysterious spiral on Jeremy's hand --

INT. HABITAT - JULIA'S ROOM - DAY

Anya wipes her tears with a tissue. Julia, with her back to Anya, opens a MEDICAL CABINET filled with pharmaceuticals, pulls down a bottle, and taps out a pill.

JULIA
I don't care what the Commander says. You lost your fiancé. You deserve a chance to mourn.

Reconsidering, Julia taps out a second pill and covertly dry swallows one. She turns around and hands the pill to Anya.

JULIA (CONT'D)
Here, this will help you relax.

ANYA
It is my fault he's dead.

JULIA
Anya, no. That's a common reaction to tragedy. We manufacture reasons to blame ourselves, but you had nothing to do with Jeremy's death.

ANYA
Yes, I did. After the party he came to my cabin and I turned him away. I told him I needed sleep -- to run compression tests on the landing pad today. But the truth is I was angry. I told him not to drink so much. I hate when people ignore me.

Abruptly, Julia's computer notepad PINGS. It's a message from Ma-Ri: "Are you with her? Is now a good time?"

JULIA
I'm so sorry. Excuse me, Anya.

Julia discreetly types back: "Yes go now."

INT. JEREMY'S ROOM - INTERCUT

The entry door opens and Ma-Ri creeps inside. She heads straight for the bed and begins searching under the sheets.

Back in her office, Julia continues with Anya.

JULIA

Sorry about that. You have my full attention now. Take your time.

ANYA

(tears filling her eyes)
Lukas believes it was no accident.
What if he's right? What if I made
Jeremy so sad he killed himself?

JULIA

Oh, he wasn't sad last night.

In Jeremy's Room, Ma-Ri finds Julia's sexy UNDERWEAR and can't help but be both surprised and a little impressed.

Anya looks up at this.

ANYA

How do you know, Julia?

She says this in a pointed way, and we wonder if she knows about Julia and Jeremy. Julia beings phumphering.

JULIA

Well, you were encouraging him not to drink, right? That shows love. Not rejection. Jeremy felt very, very loved last night.

ANYA

If he had spent the night with me, we would have been together this morning. Whatever happened in that airlock, I could have saved him.

As new waves of guilt pummel Julia --

COMMANDER GRAYSON (V.O.)

This is Commander Grayson. Go ahead, Mateo...

EXT. MARS / INT. HABITAT - SCIENCE LAB - DAY

Mateo, facing the desert, reports to Grayson in the habitat. Behind him, Harley and Jabbar pull on a rope attached to a pulley to flip Rover One back on its wheels.

MATEO

Harley jerry-rigged a fix for the busted rocker arm. I'll find the design flaw when we get back and engineer a permanent repair.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Are you mobile? Can you reach the Com Tower?

CLOSE on Jabbar and Harley in a tug of war with 3,000 pounds of metal. They strain on the rope, boots sliding, and the Rover tips slightly -- but they don't have enough power.

MATEO

It'll be a rough ride, but as long as we keep the speed below 10 kph, we should be okay.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Re-establishing communications right now is our top priority. I didn't want to alarm the others, Mateo, but that supply vessel can't land unless we can coordinate with them. This is no training drill. That ship is the colony's lifeline.

MATEO

Copy that. We're on our way. Out.

Mateo signs off and turns toward the Rover.

MATEO (CONT'D)

What's the hold up? We gotta roll.

He slaps a fender in a "let's get a move on" gesture, and the pressure is just enough to finally tip the massive vehicle off its side and it comes bouncing down on all six wheels.

When the rope goes slack, Jabbar and Harley flop back onto their asses. Oblivious to their hard work, or pratfall, Mateo climbs behind the wheel.

HARLEY

Asshole.

INT. HABITAT - JEREMY'S ROOM - DAY

Claire and Winston wheel a gurney holding a zipped BODY BAG into the room.

WINSTON

Where do we put him? The bed?

CLAIRE

Yeah.

They prepare to transfer Jeremy's body to the bed, when Claire glances at the computer terminal. An idea hits her.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

No. The desk chair.

WINSTON

Why?

CLAIRE

Just help me.

Together, they lift Jeremy's bagged body and awkwardly prop it into a sitting position in front of the computer terminal.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

Jeremy spent the last precious seconds of his life carving a symbol into his own flesh. Maybe something on his computer can tell us why.

WINSTON

You can't access his computer without...

Claire unzips the top of the body bag to expose Jeremy's ghastly face. It's all feeling quite macabre as she pries open one dead eye.

WINSTON (CONT'D)

I see what you're doing, luv. Devious.

Claire presses a button on the keyboard, the terminal lights up, and a RETINAL SCAN flashes on screen, then TURNS GREEN in approval.

MOMENTS LATER

Claire sits behind the desk now, intently exploring Jeremy's computer, clicking through folders and directories. Winston reclines in the bed with his feet up. They've propped up Jeremy's body in a corner for now.

WINSTON (CONT'D)

What are you looking for?

CLAIRE

I don't know exactly.

Claire enters a search for: FERMAT'S SPIRAL. Comes up empty.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

A man carves a spiral into his hand
as a dying declaration. Must mean
something.

WINSTON

Back home, I kept a little folder on
my laptop called *Dad Memes*. Absolute
treasure trove of internet hatred
for my billionaire ballbuster. Of
course, I had to hide it from my old
man. Try turning off "Hidden Items"
under the View tab.

Claire does as he suggests -- and a FOLDER pops up on the
desktop with an icon in the shape of a FERMAT SPIRAL.

CLAIRE

Winston! You did it!

She clicks on the spiral icon.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

Crap. It's password protected.

WINSTON

I'll bet Lukas could hack into it.

CLAIRE

I don't trust Lukas.

WINSTON

That's right. You only trust the
numptys like me.

CLAIRE

Maybe Jeremy wrote down his password
somewhere. Winston, help me look.

WINSTON

But I'm so cozy.

Ignoring him, Claire starts searching Jeremy's desk area.

EXT. SATELLITE TOWER - DAY

HIGH AND WIDE on Rover One traversing the rugged Martian
landscape toward an impressively tall, thin vertical tower.

AT THE TOWER BASE. Rover One stops. The team climbs out and
surveys the 100-foot structure of latticework metal, guyed to
the ground with tension cables, topped by a satellite array.

MATEO
I'll grab my harness.

He opens a storage compartment, but Jabbar nods to Harley, already ten feet up the tower, tool bag strapped to her hip.

JABBAR
Don't bother.

MATEO
Dammit, Harley. Get down here!

HARLEY
Why? I'm half the weight of you two tomato cans and twice as fast. And if there's a problem you'll just call me up to fix it anyway.

As Harley lightly scampers up, Jabbar turns to Mateo.

JABBAR
You know she's right.

ON THE TOWER

Harley climbs and climbs and climbs, the landscape shrinking below. She reaches a vantage point breathtakingly high, so high it makes our hearts stop, but Harley is at home up here.

Reaching the AERIAL PLATFORM, she grasps a metal carabiner attached to what looks like a heavy duty tape measure on her waist and hooks it into a strut. She keys her microphone.

HARLEY
Base, this is Rover One. I'm on the aerial platform, Atticus.

INT. HABITAT - SCIENCE LAB - INTERCUT

Atticus watches the mission via a static-filled VIDEO FEED transmitted from Harley's helmet. Grayson stands with him.

ATTICUS
How's the view up there?

HARLEY
Best view on two worlds.

ATTICUS
Don't I know it.

INT. JEREMY'S ROOM - DAY

Claire slumps back in the desk chair and turns to look at the mysterious SPIRAL ICON beckoning her on the screen.

CLAIRE

I can't find a password. How are we going to open that folder?

WINSTON

It would have been a lot easier if Jeremy had carved the password into his hand instead of a squiggle.

CLAIRE

Wait a minute, wait a minute... maybe he did. A Fermat's spiral isn't just a symbol...

ON SCREEN: Claire starts typing: $r(t)=t^2$.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

It can be written as an *equation*.

Claire hits RETURN and the icon opens to a PRIVATE DOWNLINKS folder.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

It worked! It's Jeremy's private messages.

She clicks on the folder and it opens to a subset of a DOZEN FOLDERS, each one labeled with a different colonist's name.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

Wait... these aren't just Jeremy's downlinks.

Claire clicks on the folder with her name, CLAIRE TREMBLAY, and we see a long series of video files by date. Claire clicks on one and a VIDEO POPS UP. It's CLAIRE'S MOTHER singing over a birthday cake for Claire with lit candles. Her mother's face radiates warmth and love.

CLAIRE'S MOTHER

...Bonne fête à toi. Bonne fête à toi. Bonne fête à Claire. Bonne fête à toi. Je t'aime ma chérie.

CLAIRE

He had access to all our private messages. He knew our secrets. If anyone had one worth killing for...

WINSTON

Hang about, mate -- did you just suggest murder? I don't think we're set up to handle murder. We don't have a jail cell. Is there a death penalty on Mars?

CLAIRE

I don't know what I'm suggesting, Winston. But after nine months of mind-numbing routine, we get two major system failures in a single day. The first one killed Jeremy and the second...

(a dark thought)

I need to call in that Rover Team.

Without another word, Claire rises and runs out.

EXT. SATELLITE TOWER / INT. SCIENCE LAB - INTERCUT - DAY

Atticus, with Grayson over his shoulder, talks to Harley on the Satellite Tower, watching her grainy helmet VID FEED.

ATTICUS

Okay, we're going to start by making sure the grounds are connected, then we'll check the polyphase arrestors one by one.

HARLEY

Copy that. Opening junction box.

Harley opens the junction box.

INT. HABITAT - INTERCUT - DAY

Claire RACES through a hall, rounds a corner, and encounters CHIAKI DODANI, 28, International Ethicist, born in Kyoto. Claire urgently grabs her shoulder.

CLAIRE

Chiaki. Where's Commander Grayson?

CHIAKI

In the Science Lab. What's wrong?

Claire takes off running. Chiaki curiously follows.

ATOP THE SATELLITE TOWER

Harley spots a glossy BLACK-BOX DEVICE clipped into the tangle of wires inside the junction box.

HARLEY

This doesn't look right. Can you see this?

ATTICUS

No. Too much interference.

Concerned, Grayson leans into the mic.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Harley, describe what you see so Atticus can advise.

HARLEY

There's something clipped in here... hold on a second.

Claire bursts into the room with Chiaki close behind.

CLAIRE

Is that Harley? Stop her! Get her down from there, right now!

Before Atticus can respond, Harley reaches for the black box, and her hand trips a MOTION SENSOR. A RED LIGHT flashes on and then -- KABOOM! An explosion rips through the tower.

TIME SLOWS as Harley flies backward, arcing out into space. But it's not space, there's gravity here, and Harley starts falling, arms pinwheeling.

ON THE GROUND

Mateo and Jabbar watch in horror as we RESUME REAL TIME and Harley HURTLES DOWNWARD -- until the self-retracting lifeline she hooked into the strut arrests her free fall. Her body jerks to a stop, violently, then swings hard into the tower. She dangles from her waist, back arched, like a rag doll.

MATEO

Harley! Hang on! I'm coming!

As Mateo jumps onto the struts and starts climbing, Harley, swaying 60 feet in the air, regains her senses. She reaches for the tower, but she's too far away. Hearing a tearing sound, she looks down to see the seam of her suit RIPPING where the lifeline is attached.

HARLEY

You'd better hurry.

Mateo climbs as fast as he dares.

HARLEY (CONT'D)
Mateo? I'm not dying today.

MATEO
Don't worry, I'm not gonna let you --

Abruptly, her lifeline TEARS FREE -- with a shriek, Harley lunges for the cable and grabs it. She dangles, her hands slipping down the thin cable. Mateo reaches her level --

MATEO (CONT'D)
Take my hand...

He leans out, extending a hand. Harley reaches out with one hand, so close, frightened eyes locked onto each other --

HARLEY
Mateo...

-- Harley's grip hand falters and she PLUMMETS.

MATEO
HARLEY!!!

MATEO'S POV: He helplessly watches her FALL IN SLOW MOTION, arms flailing, pleading eyes staring up at him, before we RESUME REAL TIME and she bounces off a strut and cartwheels midair.

As Harley's body SLAMS brutally to the ground we --

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. TRAINING COMPLEX - COMMISSARY - DAY

CLOSE on Harley's beguiling smile as she watches Jeremy using a spoon to shovel aside peas on a meal tray. WIDEN to reveal they are in a cavernous mess hall surrounded by tables full of young COLONIST CANDIDATES wearing uniforms with name tags.

HARLEY
Hi. Excuse me. Jeremy is it? I don't mean to be rude but... I wouldn't do that if I were you.

JEREMY
I'm not big on peas.

HARLEY
A billion toddlers would agree with you, but it doesn't matter. Starting today, scientists are going to be weighing and testing everything that goes into our bodies and comes out.

JEREMY
Everything?

PAN to Mateo sitting with them with his own tray of food.

MATEO
She's right. You can't be a picky eater on a lifeless planet. Wait till waste management training. They're going to teach us how to hydrolyze our solid waste back to carbon and make food patties out of it.

JEREMY
We gotta eat shit burgers?

Harley and Mateo look at each other and bust out laughing. Jeremy realizes he's been had and playfully flips them off.

JEREMY (CONT'D)
Oh, that's just fine. Make fun of the Southerner. Always an easy target.

Off his middle finger, Mateo nods to the CCTV cams overhead.

MATEO
Careful. The overlords are watching.

HARLEY
And judging. So smile and have fun.

They hear a SOFT SNORT and turn to Lukas sitting nearby, shaking his head to himself. Mateo clocks his name tag.

MATEO
You're not smiling, Lukas.

LUKAS
I don't feel the need to put on a show. We're mission specialists, not stage performers.

JEREMY
Oh, I don't know. If we're chosen to spend the rest of our lives in a bubble of oxygen 140 million miles from Earth, I think they're gonna want to know we can all get along.

LUKAS

Or, maybe they want to find people who don't need meaningless social interactions in order to function.

HARLEY

You are just a blast of sunshine, aren't you, Lukas?

As they talk, Jeremy picks up his dinner roll to reveal a FOLDED NOTE hidden under it. He unfolds the note to read a hand-written message: "Meet me in the south stairwell at 7 p.m. Urgent." Jeremy frowns. What the hell is this?

MATEO

So basically you want to go to Mars to be alone.

LUKAS

If I need friends, I know how to make 'em. I'm a roboticist.

Mateo and Harley trade a "watch out for this one" look.

MATEO

What about you, Harley? Why do you want to go to Mars?

HARLEY

To test myself. I'm a mechanical engineer. When shit breaks down up there, I'm gonna be the one to fix it. You?

MATEO

It's the call of adventure for me.

HARLEY

Jeremy, what about you? Why Mars?

Jeremy, still staring at the mysterious white card, slides it into his pocket then looks up, flashing his sweet smile.

JEREMY

I just wanna make my mama proud.

DR. PETTIGREW (PRE-LAP)

Ladies and gentlemen.... welcome to your first day of training.

EXT. TRAINING COMPLEX - CENTER QUAD - DAY

Dr. Pettigrew stands before the candidates, now wearing NASA-blue flight suits, their names stitched on the chest.

DR. PETTIGREW (CONT'D)

In the months ahead, you will be tested in every disaster simulation and moral reasoning scenario our think tank could devise. Our goal is simple... to determine which of you has the fiber to stay alive on an alien planet.

As Mateo absorbs that reality, he glances at Lukas standing nearby with a flat expression. Mateo can't help but wonder if maybe Lukas has the right idea about the ideal qualities.

DR. PETTIGREW (CONT'D)

For today's first exercise, you will all be separated into groups of four. Check your watch for your number, then locate your group and report to the simulators.

Mateo checks his health watch -- along with everyone around him -- and sees a big glowing NUMBER 2. He looks over at Harley, who clocks the 2 in his watch and smiles and shows him the matching 2 on hers.

UNDER NUMBER SIGN 2 - MOMENTS LATER

Mateo and Harley shake hands with JASON, a twitchy and high-strung young scientist. Around them candidates search for their groups.

MATEO

Mateo. Test pilot and systems engineer.

JASON

Jason. Microbiology.

HARLEY

Harley. Mechanical engineer.

JASON

I had a turtle named Harley.

HARLEY

Yeah? That should surprise me.

CLAIRE (O.C.)

Group two?

They all turn to see Claire.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)

Hi, I'm Claire. MD.

MATEO

I was hoping for a second chance
and here you are. That was easy.

CLAIRE

Nothing with me is easy.

Claire flashes him a suggestive look that Mateo devours.
Harley watches the charged moment with sly amusement.

HARLEY

Hi Claire, I'm Harley. There's a
turtle named after me. Ready to
kick ass?

As Harley smiles and shakes hands with Claire --

INT. TRAINING COMPLEX - DAY

In their own "Right Stuff" hero shot, Claire, Mateo, Harley
and the scrawny Jason strut side-by-side across the complex
toward a SIMULATION CHAMBER. Their TEST LEADER, 60s, white
hair, white lab coat, waits by the open door.

INT. SIMULATOR CHAMBER - DAY

One by one they enter the chamber, spinning in wonder as they
check out the detailed interior of a SPACE CAPSULE. Only
Jason appears tense, as the door seals shut behind them.

MATEO

Damn. It's a mockup of the Ares 3
capsule I'll be piloting to Mars.

CLAIRE

I would think there are a few other
candidates who might have something
to say about that.

MATEO

Let 'em.

Behind them, Harley turns to Jason.

HARLEY

I wrote my master's thesis on the
Ares 2. I developed a methodology
to assess the structural integrity
of its riveted panels.

JASON

(could care less)
Fascinating.

The voice of their Test Leader comes onto the PA.

TEST LEADER (V.O.)

Good morning, candidates. You are now the crew of the Ares 3. Mateo, you're piloting for this scenario. Claire, you're the ship MD. Harley, general crew. Your mission is to transport Jason to the Holden Crater to verify the first evidence of a microbial species living on Mars.

JASON

That's what I'm all about.

TEST LEADER (V.O.)

Your ship is five days from entry into the atmosphere, but something has gone wrong. Micrometeorites have pierced the hull to create a leak. Calculations show there will not be enough oxygen for everyone to survive. Unless one crew member is removed from the equation, all four of you will asphyxiate before landing. If you delay even fifteen minutes to make that decision, then only two of you will survive. Your simulation begins now.

A giant DIGITAL TIMER on the wall starts counting down.

HARLEY

It's a game of Lifeboat. Harsh.

MATEO

I'll volunteer.

CLAIRE

For what?

MATEO

To jump out of the lifeboat.

CLAIRE

You really are the noble one. Who'll fly and land the ship?

MATEO

Hate to shatter your outdated image of the heroic Mission Pilot, but the computer can handle all that.

HARLEY

Until a system error occurs. NASA puts that risk at one in twelve on any given Mars mission. You're the human fail-safe.

CLAIRE

I'll volunteer.

JASON

No. You're my backup. If the mission is to verify microbial life, you've got the training.

(points to Harley)

She's the redundancy. Mechanical engineer. Why don't you volunteer to die?

HARLEY

Because I don't want to, dickhead.

MATEO

(points to CCTV cam)

Harley. Big brother?

HARLEY

I don't care, he's a dickhead and someone needs to point that out before he jeopardizes all our lives. The test leader said we have fifteen minutes...

(glances at timer)

Well, fourteen now, to figure another way out of this.

JASON

You heard the scenario. The only way out is for one of us to die.

HARLEY

There's always another way.

The group trade looks. Who's going to take charge?

CLAIRE

Okay, well... let's find it.

JASON

Oh c'mon. Are we really going to indulge the mouthy grunt on the crew and waste precious...

Jason, getting worked up, suddenly struggles for breath.

CLAIRE
You okay?

JASON
I can't... breathe...

HARLEY
'Cause you're freaking out, dude.

CLAIRE
(realizing)
No. They're cutting our oxygen.

MATEO
So much for the simulation.

Jason, feeling the pressure, makes an impetuous decision. He reaches out and aggressively wraps his arms around Harley from behind, pinning her arms to her sides.

JASON
Someone help me... strap her down.

Mateo steps forward to pull him away, but Harley is quicker -- she snaps her head back into Jason's nose, then uses a crisp self-defense move to send him flying.

HARLEY
Nobody needs to die. I've got an idea.

Off Harley's bright-eyed determination --

RESUME PRESENT:

EXT. SATELLITE TOWER - DAY

Harley lies flat on her back after her fall and SCREAMS in anger as much as pain. Mateo and Jabbar rush to her side.

MATEO
Keep still. Don't move.

HARLEY
No fear of that. I can't move...
(realizing)
... anything. Below my neck.

She stares up at Mateo with eyes full of fear. Before he can even radio the hab, Claire's voice is in their helmets.

CLAIRE (V.O.)
Mateo. Jabbar. Keep her calm. Her
vitals are spiking. Give me a
report.

INT. HABITAT - SCIENCE LAB - INTERCUT - DAY

Claire monitors Harley's heart rate and oxygen saturation on
her medical tablet.

MATEO
Looks like a spinal injury.

We see this land on Claire. A spinal injury on Mars?

HARLEY
Hey, Claire?

CLAIRE
Yeah?

HARLEY
I could really use a doctor right
now.

Claire smiles as she holds back tears.

CLAIRE
I've got you, honey. We're going to
take good care of you. Mateo,
Jabbar, immobilize her. Use the
cervical collar and spinal board.

As Jabbar moves to grab the equipment, Mateo cups Harley's
cheek. Their deep affection for each other is palpable.

EXT. SATELLITE TOWER - MOMENTS LATER

Mateo and Jabbar delicately transport Harley, now wearing a
cervical collar and strapped to a c-spine board, to Rover
One. As they secure her inside, Harley looks up at Mateo.

HARLEY
Who's going to save your ass from
now on?

MATEO
You'll figure out a way.

INT. HABITAT - SCIENCE LAB - INTERCUT - DAY

Claire watches her medical monitors as she briefs Grayson,
who now stands over her shoulder. As the scene progresses,
worried colonists enter one by one to see what's happening.

CLAIRE

If I had to guess, I'd say C4 or C5. I'll know more after x-rays. An MRI. I can't do spinal surgery, but I've been trained in external fixation techniques to --

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Can you induce a coma?

CLAIRE

Ah, sure, but... why?

COMMANDER GRAYSON

We're now down two colonists. I can't spare you to nursemaid a quadriplegic. I have a transport ship on the last leg of an eight-month journey and it can't land tomorrow without communications.

CLAIRE

Oh, we've got way bigger problems than that, Commander.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

What are you talking about?

PAN the faces of all the colonists who have gathered to watch the drama play out. A WARNING BEEP on a medical monitor interrupts. Claire checks the monitor and her face fills with sudden alarm --

INT. ROVER ONE - DRIVING - DAY

Jabbar drives while Mateo tends to Harley in back.

CLAIRE

Rover Team One, I'm detecting signs of dysrhythmia. You need to get Harley here fast, before she goes into arrest.

MATEO

We can't drive faster than 10 kph. Not without breaking that strut.

CLAIRE

Just... get her here.

EXT. MARS DESERT - DAY

AERIAL POV of the Rover One creeping along below, surrounded and virtually swallowed by the vast nothingness of the red desert. A DUST DEVIL swirls nearby.

INT. HABITAT - SCIENCE LAB - INTERCUT - DAY

Now the entire colony gathers around Claire, breathlessly watching. Atticus enters last and moves to Claire's side.

ATTICUS

I've got a drone over them.

He punches in a VIDEO FEED on Claire's monitors. It's the AERIAL VIEW we were just looking at.

ATTICUS (CONT'D)

They're two clicks out.

CLAIRE

(willing it)

They'll make it.

INT. ROVER ONE - INTERCUT - DAY

Mateo hovers over Harley in the back. Their eyes locked.

HARLEY

Are you holding my hand?

TILT DOWN to reveal that Mateo is, in fact, doing just that.

MATEO

I am.

HARLEY

You doing anything dirty with it?

MATEO

Fuck off.

EXT. ROVER ONE - INTERCUT - DAY

CLOSE ON the giant left front wheel of Rover One. PUSH IN to the rattly MAKESHIFT STRUT holding it in place. It bounces up and down, absorbing the rough terrain, then -- SNAP!

The strut collapses and a corner of the Rover dips and slams into the dirt. Dirt and gravel spray the front windshield as the Rover LURCHES to a stop in the Martian soil.

In the Rover, Mateo tumbles to the ground, but quickly rises and moves back to Harley, who's still firmly strapped down.

HARLEY
... I'm alright.

In the hab, the colonists gasp at seeing the Rover nosedive.

CLAIRE
Rover One. Status report.

JABBAR
We're okay. Strut gave out.

COMMANDER GRAYSON
You still have five wheels. You
should be operable.

Jabbar tries to accelerate, but the damaged wheel, jammed
sideways, just digs deeper into the regolith. Jabbar stops.

MATEO
Not without removing the entire
wheel assembly. That's a two-hour
job, minimum. We've got oxygen for
half that time. Any ideas?

HARLEY (V.O.)
This is going to work.

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. TRAINING COMPLEX - SIMULATOR CHAMBER - DAY

CLOSE on Harley scrolling through Ares 3 structural specs at
a computer terminal, struggling to breathe.

HARLEY (CONT'D)
I just need to verify my proof.

Claire and Mateo sit huddled together, fighting for oxygen,
leaning into each other for support -- an intimate moment.
After witnessing their coldness on Mars, it's strange to see
them so cozy. Claire glances at the timer.

CLAIRE
Less than a minute, Harley.

HARLEY
Almost there.

JASON
It's not too late to kill her.

HARLEY
Yes! The CDRA system on Ares 3...
it's the same as Ares 2.

Satisfied, Harley turns to the CCTV camera watching them, standing on wobbly knees, about to pass out.

HARLEY (CONT'D)

Hello out there! I think we have a solution... to our little oxygen problem? With the hull damage... we're leaking O-2 faster than we can scrub our CO-2... but if we shut off the O-2 tanks, the system will clean the dirty air... provide oxygen to reach Mars... weird, I know, cutting off our air supply to breathe... but we can all live.

The timer reaches zero and loudly BUZZES. After a beat, the chamber door opens and the Test Leader toddles inside with a GUARD. The four colonist hopefuls gulp in the fresh air.

TEST LEADER

I'm sorry, but your decision just cost the lives of half your crew.

JASON

Way to go, Imagineer.

HARLEY

(focused on Test Leader)

No, that's not right. We solved your puzzle.

TEST LEADER

It wasn't a puzzle. This was a test to determine how you function under pressure.

(turns to Jason)

Which you did not. You've been dismissed. The guard will escort you out of the facility.

As the guard takes Jason by the arms and pulls him out --

JASON

Me!? Wait a minute, she's the one who got us killed! This is rigged!

Harley, troubled, turns back to the Test Leader.

HARLEY

Just because this wasn't intended to be a puzzle, it doesn't mean our solution was wrong.

MATEO

Maybe you should ask your engineer to, you know, check your numbers.

TEST LEADER

Dozens of engineers and scientists devised these exercises. I assure you the numbers are correct.

CLAIRE

Can you really? Assure us? Feels presumptive without checking. What if the intense pressure you put us under resulted in a technical discovery that could save lives?

Off the Test Leader, surprised but intrigued --

INT. TRAINING COMPLEX - COMMISSARY - NIGHT

CLOSE on three tumblers full of green juice clinking a toast, as Harley and Mateo and Claire celebrate their success.

ALL THREE

To Mars!

CLAIRE

This occasion calls for something stronger than cold-pressed greens.

MATEO

You helped us all today, Harley. I'd kiss you if they'd let me.

HARLEY

I'd kiss you both if they let me.
(leans close)

Hey, you guys, we're going to make it to Mars, okay? The three of us. Whatever it takes, right?

RESUME:

EXT. MARS DESERT - INTERCUT - MOMENTS LATER

CLOSE on Harley's pained face. Mateo and Jabbar carry her broken body on a spinal board across the desert scape. It's slow going in their bulky EVA suits. We hear their labored breathing.

The colonists continue to watch via drone in the hab.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Is she going to make it, Claire?

CLAIRE
I don't know.

Back outside, Jabbar and Mateo traverse a rocky outcropping, when Jabbar's foot stumbles on the rough surface. He stays upright but Harley's body shifts suddenly.

MATEO
Harley, are you okay?

Harley's heart monitor BEEPS AN ALERT.

CLAIRE
No no no...
(into radio)
Mateo, she's going into cardiac
arrest. Set her down!

Mateo and Jabbar stop and set Harley on the ground.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
She's not breathing.

MATEO
What do I do, Claire? *Claire?!*

CLAIRE
You need to circulate blood to her
vital organs. Chest compressions.
Remember your training. Fast and
hard. I'll count with you... one,
two, three, four, five...

Mateo administers compressions. Claire eyes the monitors.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Blood oxygen still dropping.

MATEO
I can't get downward movement.

JABBAR
Together. Come on.

The two men try together, but the compression suit has a Hard Upper Torso (HUT) for load bearing -- and it's not giving.

CLAIRE
It's not working, Mateo. Get
Harley's heart pumping or she's
going to die.

Jabbar grimly looks up at Mateo.

JABBAR
No way with this chest plate.

MATEO
Harley always found a way.
(focusing)
In training, they said a human body
exposed to the Martian atmosphere
can tolerate thirty seconds before
severe ebullism, right?

Claire realizes what Mateo is thinking.

CLAIRE
Mateo, you can't!

Mateo pulls out his UTILITY KNIFE.

MATEO
Too late.

Tears in his eyes, he looks down at Harley's serene face.

MATEO (CONT'D)
I'm sorry...

He SLICES an opening in her pressure suit, right above the
hard chest plate. *PSSSTTTTTT*. Air comes rushing out. Mateo
slides his hands into the ragged gash, under the chest piece,
and he starts chest compressions.

Back in the hab, Grayson urgently turns to Claire.

COMMANDER GRAYSON
Time the exposure.

Claire starts a timer, as Mateo continues compressions.

MATEO
C'mon, Harley...

CLAIRE
Ten seconds...

MATEO
Breathe!

Jabbar looks down at Harley and sees veins in her neck SPIDER
WEBBING, her face SWELLING AND CONTORTING, as the fluids in
her body start boiling. Mateo desperately continues CPR.

JABBAR
We're killing her.

In the hab, Claire and the colonists watch in pin-drop silence as the seconds tick by.

CLAIRE
Twenty seconds...

MATEO
God dammit, Harley! You've never
backed down from a challenge in
your life! Now breathe!

Just then, a BEEP on Claire's tablet announces a pulse.

CLAIRE
She's got a pulse! Close her up!

Harley's body GASPS for oxygen that isn't there. Jabbar leans in with UTILITY TAPE that he has ready and quickly seals the tear in her pressure suit.

JABBAR
Got it...

We hear the sound of her suit PRESSURIZING. Mateo and Jabbar collapse into each in relief, as CHEERS rise in the habitat.

MATEO
We're bringing her home.

Off Claire's face, relieved, angry, conflicted --

FLASHBACK TO:

EXT. TRAINING COMPLEX - RUNNING TRAIL - LATE DAY

CLOSE on Claire's enthusiastic face as she sprints toward the finish line of a competitive 10k run for the Mars candidates. A TRAINER monitors the times.

TRAINER
Forty-one thirty-three, thirty-four,
thirty-five. Nice job, Tremblay.

Claire finishes and catches her breath, hands on hips as she breathes in the pristine Pacific Northwest air. Mateo trots up with a water.

MATEO
Not bad.

CLAIRE
Be a lot easier on Mars. I'd weigh
forty-five pounds with the gravity.
Imagine that.

MATEO

Why imagine? Just get there. How else are you going to spend the rest of your life with me?

Claire looks at his irrepressible smile and smiles back.

CLAIRE

Walk back?

EXT. TRAINING CENTER - WOODS - SUNSET

Claire and Mateo walk through a wooded trail to the training center. A few other candidates are in front and behind them, but not close enough to hear them. The silence between them is charged. Claire glances up at a CCTV camera in the trees.

CLAIRE

If we weren't bugs under a microscope...

MATEO

We'd have other ways to get acquainted.

CLAIRE

Which would be a lot more fun.

MATEO

Lots of opportunity for that once we're up there.

CLAIRE

Don't get your hopes up, Mateo. I should warn you, I always come in second to my little sister.

MATEO

Your sister. The girl you met?

CLAIRE

Adrienne. She's a savant, literally. Has never lost anything. To anyone.

MATEO

So why are you even here?

CLAIRE

Chance of a lifetime. I couldn't live with myself if I didn't try.

MATEO

So fatalistic.

CLAIRE
No, just realistic.

Mateo stops walking and turns to face Claire.

MATEO
Listen, I know there are pilots and engineers here with higher test scores than me, but I guarantee you none of them want it more. That's what I plan to show the evaluators.

CLAIRE
So all I gotta do is want it more than my sister to reach Mars?

MATEO
Well it sounds dumb when you say it like that.

CLAIRE
(letting down her guard)
Will you help me?

That one instant of vulnerability is all it takes to turn the spark between these two into a blast furnace. It happens before our eyes, as they stare at deeply into each other.

MATEO
I'd do anything to take this ride with you, Claire...

They both take an involuntary step closer and Mateo raises a hand to Claire's cheek to kiss her --

HARLEY (O.C.)
Careful. Cameras.

They both step back, busted, and turn to see Harley and Jeremy walking down the trail. Off Harley's winning smile --

INT. HABITAT - MEDICAL BAY - LATER

CLOSE ON Harley's bruised and swollen face, sedated inside a decompression chamber, breathing with a ventilator. Claire checks her vitals one last time before heading out.

INT. HABITAT - COMMON ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Claire enters the lounge area where Grayson and the colonists quietly wait for a medical report.

MATEO
How's she doing?

CLAIRE

She took a beating out there, but
she's stable. Her heart's strong.

A wave of relief washes over them.

JABBAR

Alhamdulillah.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

And her spine?

CLAIRE

Harley is exhibiting signs of total
paralysis below the C-4 vertebra.
No reflexes. No pain response.

WINSTON

Is it permanent, you think?

CLAIRE

Hard to tell until spinal shock
resolves.

MATEO

But she's alive. We pulled her
through together, didn't we?

Mateo extends a conciliatory hand to Claire's shoulder, but
she pushes it away. Pushed to the edge by Jeremy's death and
Harley's injury.

CLAIRE

Harley never should've left the hab
in the first place.

MATEO

What're you saying?

CLAIRE

We had multiple systems failures
and a fatality and you had her
climbing a fucking coms tower. Has
anyone stopped to question why we
lost contact with Earth the same
day we lost a colonist?

JULIA

What are you saying, Claire?

CLAIRE

I don't think Jeremy's death or
what happened to Harley were
accidents.

COMMANDER GRAYSON
That's a hell of a claim without
evidence.

CLAIRE
Who said I don't have evidence?
Follow me.

Claire turns on her heels and walks out. The others look at each other, stunned but curious, and follow.

INT. HABITAT - HALLWAY - DAY

Claire calmly moves down the hallway with all the available colonists trailing behind her.

INT. JEREMY'S ROOM - DAY

The colonists gather around the door watching Claire unzip Jeremy's face in the body bag, now propped back up in the chair, and unlock his computer with a retinal scan.

COMMANDER GRAYSON
Claire... what are you doing?

ANYA
This is so wrong.

CLAIRE
I'm sorry, Anya. Before Jeremy died, he carved the password to his computer into his hand -- in blood. He wanted us to see what I'm about to show you.

Claire rolls the chair with Jeremy's body away, bends over the computer, and types in the password.

CLAIRE (CONT'D)
Jeremy had our personal messages from Earth. And from each other.

LUKAS
That's not possible. The system encrypts our DMS for security and privacy.

CLAIRE
And yet he had them. All of them. Julia, you said yourself we all keep secrets. Well, what if one of us has a secret worth killing for?

Claire clicks on the Fermat's spiral icon now on screen, but this time, it opens to just one PRIVATE DOWNLINKS folder with Jeremy's name. The rest are now gone.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

I only see see Jeremy's DMs.

CLAIRE

No. No... this folder had all our video downlinks. Thousands of them.

(to Winston)

Right, Winston? You saw them.

All heads swivel to Winston.

WINSTON

I saw a video of... something. Some woman singing. Maybe a relative of Jeremy's?

CLAIRE

Winston. Are you serious? That was *my* private message. From my mom. You're a coward. Unless -- did you delete them?

Enraged now, Claire makes an aggressive move toward Winston, but the others intervene, shouting as they hold her back.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Stand down, Claire! Now!

MATEO

Don't do this --

Claire back away from the group, eyeing each of them with suspicion.

CLAIRE

One of you did this... I know it.

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. TRAINING COMPLEX - COMMISSARY - NIGHT

In a replay, Claire, Mateo and Harley clink their glasses.

ALL THREE

To Mars!

PAN to Jeremy sitting nearby, watching them, then he turns back to the WHITE CARD he holds: "Meet me in the south stairwell at 7 p.m. Urgent." Jeremy glances at a wall clock: 6:55 p.m.

INT. SOUTH STAIRWELL - NIGHT

Jeremy steps into the stairwell to find a white-coated test leader waiting for him, an angular-faced man in his 50s with a calm manner and penetrating eyes. We'll call him ARTHUR.

ARTHUR

Don't worry, Jeremy, there are no cameras in here, and your watch is out of range from the monitors -- but we don't have much time. I know your mother's dying.

JEREMY

Whoa whoa, hold on --

ARTHUR

She's a young woman with high-risk neuroblastoma and she'll be dead in five years without gene therapy, which your family cannot afford. I've been authorized to fund her treatment.

JEREMY

What is this? Who are you?

ARTHUR

In return, all my employer requires is for you to screen the DMS of your fellow colonists when you're chosen as the Chief Communications Engineer.

JEREMY

This isn't real. You have no way of knowing whether I'll be chosen.

ARTHUR

To the contrary. My employer will make sure of it.

JEREMY

Who's your employer?

Arthur looks back at Jeremy but doesn't say a word.

JEREMY (CONT'D)

I get it. This is a test, right? A way to spot the bad eggs? Psychological fitness and all that?

ARTHUR

Irrelevant questions. The only one that matters, Jeremy, is what would you do to save your mother's life?

JEREMY

Anything.

ARTHUR

It's not a test. This colony has a bigger purpose than people are being led to believe. I'll be in touch with further instructions. As soon as I have your mother admitted to Ascension Providence Hospital for immediate treatment.

Jeremy reacts, confused, overwhelmed, but deeply grateful.

JEREMY

Thank you.

ARTHUR

Once you start down this road there's no turning back. Are you okay with that, Jeremy?

As Jeremy, determined to save his mother, nods his head --

RESUME PRESENT:

INT. HABITAT - GREENHOUSE - DAY

CLOSE ON: Jeremy, his face visible but artfully filtered by layers of white biodegradable gauze, surrounded by greenery. He lies on a raised earthen platform inside the greenhouse, topped with regolith to protect from radiation, and side-lit with massive sun mirrors.

As SOMBER MUSIC plays, Anya steps close to Jeremy's body, tears in her eyes. She lays the first sheet of fine white gauze over his face like a death shroud.

Atticus steps forward next, as in a ceremonial burial ritual, the colonists start filing by, one by one, and draping layers of gauze over Jeremy.

Mateo looks around, noticing Claire's absence, and turns to Ma-Ri and Julia now standing next to him.

MATEO

Where's Claire?

MA-RI

Probably building a crime board.
Can you believe she thinks one of
us is a killer? Girl lost control.

MATEO

Claire never loses control.

JULIA

Are you saying that you believe her
delusions? Maybe we should schedule
a session, Mateo.

Mateo frowns at Julia and Ma-Ri, whose serene Stepford manner suddenly has him wondering who to trust. Mateo turns to watch the colonists continue the ceremonial burial. Jeremy's body is now fully shrouded.

EXT. MARS COLONY - NIGHT

Two moons, Phobos and Deimos, hang in the night sky above the desolate surface of Mars.

INT. HABITAT - COMMON ROOM - NIGHT

All the colonists, except for Claire, are gathered in the lounge. Winston breaks out a bottle of Japanese whiskey and starts pouring a round for everyone.

ANYA

Is that whiskey?

WINSTON

Not *just* whiskey. Yamazaki 18.

CHIAKI

Put it away, Winston.

WINSTON

If you insist.

He throws back the shot he just poured. Across from him, Ma-Ri holds her ACTION FIGURE in her hand.

MA-RI

I thought this was so badass when
they showed it to me. My own action
figure. Feels kind of lame now.

Atticus looks to the shelf holding the other action figures.

ATTICUS

Hey... one of them's missing. Who
took Jeremy?

They all look at each other. Nobody speaks up.

LUKAS

Twelve little colonists flew toward heaven. One stepped out for air and then there were eleven.

JULIA

That's morbid.

MATEO

Hey, if someone took it, put it back. Tonight. This isn't a game.

ANYA

Whenever it shows up, I want to keep it... to remember Jeremy.

(to Julia)

Unless that's unhealthy.

JULIA

Oh trust me, I'd take all my men in plastic if I could. With an on/off switch.

Commander Grayson enters.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Okay crew, let's call it a night.

WINSTON

Come on, Mum. Have a drink with us.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

Gotta get coms up and running first light to receive that transport ship. Not to mention the landing pad's still not ready. So let's all turn in.

MATEO

One drink, cappy. For Jeremy.

JABBAR

And Harley.

Grayson looks around the group and sees faces in mourning.

COMMANDER GRAYSON

One drink.

Winston pours Grayson a finger of the Yamazaki 18 and slides it across the table to her. Grayson raises her glass.

COMMANDER GRAYSON (CONT'D)
To fallen friends.

The colonists echo her toast and everyone drinks. Beat. A heaviness settles over the room. Everyone feels it.

INT. HABITAT - CLAIRE'S ROOM - NIGHT

Claire sits up in bed. On her tablet, she watches Harley's grainy helmet VID FEED in the moments before the explosion.

HARLEY (ON VIDEO)
This doesn't look right. Can you
see this?
(then)
There's something clipped in
here... hold on a second.

Harley's words abruptly cut off -- as the EXPLOSION kills the VID FEED. As Claire sits back, suspicion growing, the famous baseline of the bluesy rock anthem "I've Gotta Get Out of This Place" by THE ANIMALS kicks in and carries us into a MUSIC MONTAGE --

INT. HABITAT - ANYA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Anya lies in bed, sobbing. Alone. Deeply anguished.

INT. HABITAT - JULIA'S ROOM - NIGHT

CLOSE on Jeremy's Psychiatric File open on Julia's computer screen. PAN to find Julia standing before her medical cabinet full of pharmaceuticals.

She selects a bottle and pops a pill, then thinks again and pours out three more pills and swallows them. She closes her eyes in relief. In addition to being unethical, our shrink is an addict.

INT. HABITAT - ATTICUS' ROOM - NIGHT

Atticus sits on his bed typing on his computer tablet. CAMERA comes around to REVEAL Atticus sending a message on a chat platform in CHINESE. After a beat, a mysterious message in Chinese comes back.

INT. HABITAT - MA-RI'S ROOM - NIGHT

Ma-ri lies in bed, wide awake, mind racing. She suddenly sits up and opens the drawer of a bedside table and pulls out a small ACTION FIGURE -- Jeremy. Worried she'll be found out, she finds a better hiding place and tucks it away.

INT. HABITAT - CHIAKI'S ROOM - NIGHT

Jabbar gets ready for bed. Chiaki watches him with concern. When he crawls under the sheets, she curls against him and speaks softly into his ear.

CHIAKI

It's a tragedy, but you have one
less thing to worry about now.

INT. HABITAT - LUKAS' ROOM - NIGHT

In a leather-bound journal, Lukas' hand inks an ILLUSTRATION covering the entire page -- a disturbing visual cacophony of violent horror imagery.

PUSH IN to one corner of the drawing, where we can clearly see the Fermat SPIRAL IMAGE that Jeremy carved into his hand.

INT. HABITAT - WINSTON'S ROOM - NIGHT

Winston, bottle of scotch by his side, sits over a portable shortwave radio, fiddling with the bands. He keys the mic.

WINSTON

Patriot 2, this is Patriot 1.
Radio check. You read, bruv?

INT. HABITAT - MATEO'S ROOM - NIGHT

Mateo enters his room and flops down on his bed. In front of him sits a FRAMED PHOTO of his folks. He reaches for the frame and pulls out a SECOND PHOTO hidden behind the first, which he stares at somberly.

REVEAL that the hidden photo Mateo stares at is a WEDDING PHOTO of Mateo and Claire at the altar.

INT. HABITAT - KITCHEN - NIGHT

From a mysterious POV: We're watching Grayson seated from behind. A cup of steaming tea next to her. Our POV moves closer. Over Grayson's shoulder, a home video on her tablet comes into view of a 3-year-old BOY waving at camera.

GRANDSON

Come home, Nana! We miss you!

COMMANDER GRAYSON

(softly)
I miss you, baby.

On the tablet, the boy starts running in dizzying circles, laughing. Hearing movement behind her, Grayson turns and looks straight INTO CAMERA with familiarity.

COMMANDER GRAYSON (CONT'D)

Hey, I meant it when I told you to
get some sleep. You need to be --

Abruptly, a hammer-like object SMASHES into Grayson's head with a sickening THUD, jerking it violently out of frame, just as The Animals' chorus hits --

THE ANIMALS

*We gotta get out of this place. If
it's the last thing we ever do...*

CLOSE on a hand in a latex gloves scrawling a message on the wall over Grayson's body using her blood: "NO ONE'S COMING!"

THE ANIMALS (CONT'D)

*We gotta get out of this place.
'Cause girl, there's a better life
for me and you.*

CUT WIDE ON MARS, a giant red ball in the blackness of space, with the confirmation that Claire was right -- one of our colonists is a calculated, cold-blooded killer.

SMASH TO BLACK.

THE END

*